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DEPARTMENT OF MATHEMATICS RIVERSIDE, CALIFORNIA 92521-0135

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Dear Ivan Penkov:

This is a letter for Alex Hoffnung, a graduate student doing his Ph.D. work with me in the math department here at U. C. Riverside. He has applied for funding for the summer school you are running on structures in Lie representation theory.

Alex Hoffnung is an energetic and ambitious mathematician. Before beginning his dissertation, he has written three papers with me. The first, 'Convenient Categories of Smooth Spaces', concerns differential geometry. The second, 'Categorified Symplectic Geometry and the Classical String'. written with another grad student and myself as coauthors, was about categorified Lie algebras (called 'Lie 2-algebras') and how they arise as algebras of observables in classical string theory.

For his thesis, Alex Hoffnung is working on the categorification of Hecke algebras and Hall algebras. Together with another grad student and myself, he wrote a paper on the foundations of my approach to this subject, called 'Groupoidification Made Easy'. Then, during the winter quarter of this year, Hoffnung visited Columbia to study Michael Khovanov's approach to categorification. While there, he began work with Khovanov's collaborator Aaron Lauda on a paper about cyclotomic Hecke algebras and their categorification.

Alex Hoffnung's research is closely connected to the themes of your summer school, so he would profit greatly from attending it. Alex also looks forward to interacting with some of the invited speakers — particularly Wolfgang Soergel and Catharina Stroppel, who work on subjects closely related to his research, as well as Gregg Zuckerman, whom he knows from visiting Yale.

I hope you can give him financial support!

Sincerely,
John Baez